received a call from the office of the national security adviser (NSA) asking me to meet him. The next day we met in the NSA's office. After the usual pleasantries, he mentioned that the government was considering me for a gubernatorial position, and asked for my views. Frankly, I was not expecting such a question and after a pause, replied that it would be a great honour to serve my country. Then he threw another bombshell and said that he had learnt that I would prefer to be an ambassador. I had no hesitation in telling him that he had been misinformed. I had tea and while leaving his office, I turned back and expressed my desire that if something was going to come my way, it would make me happier if there was a challenge in it. I came back and shared the gist of the conversation with Rohini. Then we forgot all about it. In the meanwhile, a close friend of mine offered me a vice-presidentship and an equal status to him in his multinational company, with unbelievably attractive terms and conditions. I requested him to give me six months' time. If nothing came up from the government, I would gladly join him after the 'cooling off' period.

On 24 January 2008 I received a message from the office of the home minister that he wished to have a meeting with me. It was a very brief and pointed meeting. The minister, Shivraj Patil, asked me if I was willing to accept a governorship in the northeast. I replied in the affirmative, saying that it would be a great honour. He said, 'I am moving the file now to the prime minister with the recommendation that you should be appointed as the governor of Arunachal Pradesh.' I thanked him and left his office. Till that day I had no inkling that the ministry of home affairs was the nodal ministry for the appointment of governors. Things moved with lightning speed thereafter. By mid-day on 25 January, I was rung up by the secretary to the president of India, Christy Fernandez, congratulating me on being appointed as the governor. I thanked him and asked him if the warrant of appointment could be sent to me. He confirmed that it was on the way. I asked him if any date had been specified. He said it was left to me, and that my appointment would take effect from the day I was sworn in. I got the first congratulatory call from Arunachal Pradesh from Prashant